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ALT 110: CRITICAL READING AND RESPONSE

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LESSON 1

INTRODUCTION TO CRITICAL READING AND RESPONSE

Various scholars refer to critical reading in different ways such “critical reading “textual reading” or “active reading”. Bartholomae and Petrosky while describing critical reading as active reading in ways of reading write.

Reading involves a fair measure of push and shove. You make your mark on the book and it makes its mark on you. Reading is not simply a matter of lunging back and waiting for a piece or its author, to tell you what the writing has to say. In fact, one of the difficult things about reading is that the pages before you will begin to speak only when the authors are silent and you begin to speak in their place, sometimes for them- doing their work, continuing their projects- and sometimes for yourself , following your own agenda (1)

In all the above except, Bartholomae and Petrosky describe the reading process in pro-active terms. Meaning of every text is “made”, not received. Readers need to “push and shove” in order to create their own unique content of every text they read. Therefore, this describes what a critical reader ones because, it is up to the reader of a given text to make the text “speak” by talking with and against the text, and by questioning and expanding it. For that reader to be able make a text “speak”, he/she must have critical reading skills such analytical skills, evaluative

skills and synthesizing skills. These skills enable the reader to see relationships of ideas and use them as an aid in reading and in the process of making out the meaning of a text.

Stop and ponder:

What is critical reading?

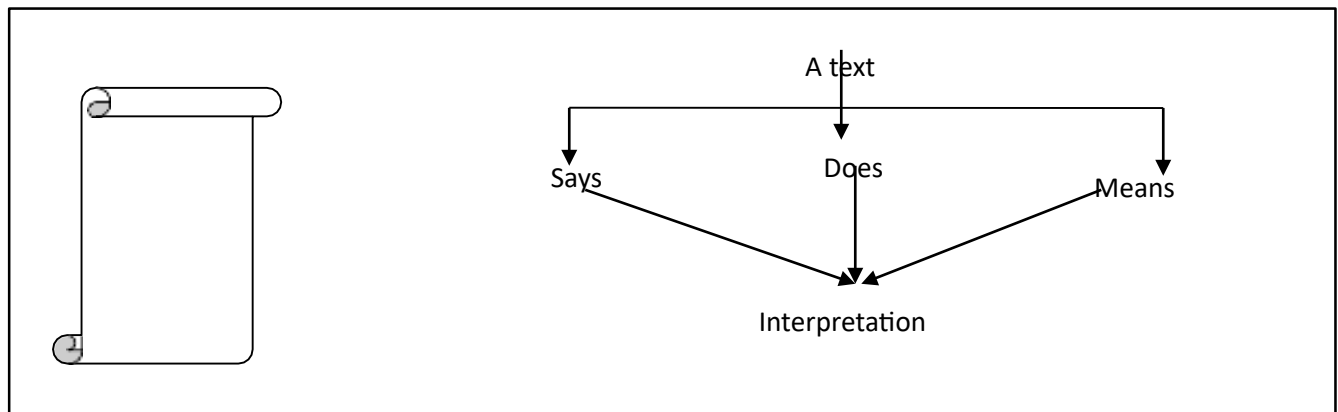
From the foregoing, we can define critical reading as a careful, active, reflective, and analytic reading. This indicates on the one hand, had a critical reader of any single text provides but one portrayal of the facts, one individual's "take" on the subject matter. On the other hand, it shows that a critical reader might read the same text to appreciate how a particular perspective on the events and a particular selection of facts can lead to a particular understanding of the same text. Sometimes we read just for pleasure or entertainment; sometimes we read just to obtain information, taking it for granted that the information is reliable.

However, critical reading goes steps further than reading for mere pleasure, critical reading means analyzing and evaluating what we read- to repeat, working out what is good and what is not, and why, in this way, critical readers recognize not only what a text says, but also how the text portrays the subject matter. They recognize the various ways in which each and every text is the unique creation of a unique author.

Having recognized what a text says, critical reading reflects, on what the text does by asking questions such as; is the text offering examples? Arguing? Appealing for sympathy? Does the text use contrast to clarify a point? Finally, critical readers then infer what the text, as a whole, means, based on the earlier analysis. Each mode of analysis can be distinguished by the subject matter of the discussion as shown:

† What a text says- restatement- talks about the same topic as the original text

- ✚ What a text does- description- discusses aspects of the discussion itself.
- ✚ What a text means- interpretation- analyzes the text and asserts a meaning for the text as a whole.



In other words, critical reading is an active approach to reading that involves an in depth examination of the text. Additionally, the text is broken down into various components and examined critically in order to achieve a meaningful understanding of its concerns. It is worth noting that critical reading is not simply close and careful reading. Therefore, critical reading is an active process as opposed to passive.

Critical reading is not a passive process since impassive reading; the reading is largely inactive, there is low motivation to examine the text critically or at an in-depth level, important pieces of data and assumptions may be missed, and lastly assumptions that are perceived by the passive reader are accepted at face value or are examined superficially. On the other hand, active reading involves interacting with the text and therefore requires more energy than passive reading. An

active reader invests a lot of effort to understand the text. Critical reading always involves active reading. An active reader identifies important arguments and examines the critically.

To read critically, one must actively recognize and analyze evidence upon the page. Critical reading assumes that each author offers a portrayal of the topic. Critical reading thus relies on an examination of those choices that any and all authors must make when framing a presentation: choices of content, language, and structure. In the end, readers take control of the text, and not just repeat its assertions. At its core, critical reading involves becoming the author of one's own understating.

IMPORTANCE OF CRITICAL READING AND RESPONSE

Critical reading and response aims at accomplishing the following goals to:

- i. Recognize an author's purpose which involves inferring a basis for choices of content and language of any text.
- ii. Recognizing tone and persuasive elements in the text and which involves classifying the nature of language choices.
- iii. Recognizing bias in and text which involves classifying the nature of pattern of choice of content and language.

- iv. Critical reading and response completes the meaning of a text by providing a critical interpretation of the text in question
- v. Helps readers to appreciate a work of art

It is important to note that none of the goals of critical reading and response actually refers to something from the text but each requires inferences and evidence from within the text.

SUMMARY

Critical reading is a deliberate act of testing out concepts, trying ideas on for size. A critical reader tries not only to think of arguments to refute what he reads; he tries to think of extra arguments to support it. Only then does he weigh the argument carefully and come to a decision. He also tries to determine in what ways the argument may be relevant and relate those ideas to his own life. Rather than merely seeking to “trash” an argument entirely, a wise reader acknowledges that some parts of an argument are more compelling than others, and tries to figure out why.

LESSON 2

DEFINING CHARACTERISTICS OF CRITICAL READING AND RESPONSE

Introduction

We have observed that critical reading is a process that is governed by particular practices for one to arrive at a particular meaning. The practices are considered to be the defining characteristics of critical reading and response.

Critical readers confront a text using any of the following ways;

- Basing on the content of the text
- Basing on the content of the text
- Basing on the language of the text
- Basing on the structure of the text.

This implies that there are three specific practices that critical readers engages themselves in while aiming at deducing the meaning of a text;

1. Critical readers are consciously aware of the choice of content of a given text and focus on it critically

This implies that they interact with the texts they read by questioning them, responding to them, and expanding them, usually by making their own responses to them in writing. While examining the content of a text, critical readers look at;

- a) The nature of the examples and illustrations that an author uses to explain, support and substantiate his/her ideas, and the details presented within the description.
- b) The nature of evidence that an author marshals or involves to support his arguments

By focusing on the content, critical readers are able to

- i. Identify the uniqueness of a text in terms of content
- ii. Distinguish between assertions of fact, opinion, and belief
- iii. Are aware whether evidence consists of references to published data, anecdotes, or speculation, and hence evaluate the persuasiveness of a text accordingly.

2. Critical readers pay particular attention to how language is being used in a text. In this case, they examine the underlying figures of speech and stylistic features that help an author to communicate effectively to his readers. In this way, critical readers notice the forms

of imagery, symbolism, and any other style that has been used in the text and how all these stylistic features communicate intended message to the intended audience

3. Critical readers also examine the structure of a text in discussion.

In looking at the structure of a text, critical readers examine

- i. The movement of ideas in the text from beginning to the end
- ii. The relationship of ideas throughout the discussion.
- iii. Distinguish between assertions offered as reason or conclusion, cause or effect, evidence or illustration
- iv. Recognize patterns of contrast and distinguish whether contrasting ideas are shown to be dissimilar, competing or contradictory.

Critical reading and response proceeds in three steps

I. Recognizing the text

This is usually the initial step in critical reading and it involves recognizing a text as a presentation in its own right. In this step readers recognize the following elements:

- ✚ Beginning, middle and end
- ✚ Illustrations used to support arguments
- ✚ Evidence to support arguments
- ✚ Nature of language used
- ✚ Chronology of events

II. Describing the various aspects of the text

In this step, critical readers embarked on various aspects of the text and classifying the nature of the material within the text into themes and sub- themes with illustrations to support such classifications. This process involves classifying

- ✚ The nature of the structure of the text
- ✚ The nature of the language employed
- ✚ The nature of the examples invoked
- ✚ The nature of the illustrations brought to bear
- ✚ Explain why all aspects of the text are depicted that way in the text.

III. Making inferences

This is the final step in critical reading and it involves inferring the underlying assumptions and perspectives of the discussion, taking into account of all of the elements of the text being as they are throughout the text as a whole. This step is concerned less with sequential development and more with recognizing patterns of elements interwoven throughout the presentation as a whole. It explains:

- ✚ What is achieved by describing topics a certain way
- ✚ What is assumed by selecting certain types of evidence

DEFINING CHARACTERISTICS OF CRITICAL READERS

Critical readers exhibit the following characteristics

- They are honest with themselves ○ They
- resist manipulation ○ They overcome

confusion ○ They ask questions ○ They base
judgments on evidence ○ They look for
connections between subjects ○ They are
intellectually independent

ANALYSIS AND INFERENCE AS TOOLS FOR CRITICAL READING AND RESPONSE

We have observed that critical reading is an analytic activity. The reader rereads a text to identify patterns of information, values, assumptions, and language usage in the text. These elements are tied together in an interpretation, an assertion of an underlying meaning of the text as a whole.

Analysis explains what a work of literature means, and how it means it. This implies that analysis is essentially a justification of and a clarification of an interpretation which shows how one arrived at the meaning of a text.

Therefore, analysis does not 'tear apart' a work of art as many people think but analysis in one way appreciates a work of art in analysis;

1. Develops a deeper understanding and a fuller appreciation of a work of arts. Analysis is aimed at seeing more, to uncover or create richer, denser, more interesting meanings to a text.
2. Leads to a more astute and powerful use of the tools of meaning on the reader's part
3. Helps us to identify culture delineation and the ideological aspects of a work of art, it is worth noting that art is not eternal and timeless but is situated historically, socially, intellectually, written and read at particular times, with particular intent, under

particular use in understanding our own culture and time, but has historical applications as well.

4. Help us understand the way ideas and feelings are talked about in our culture or in other times and cultures hence developing different kinds of understanding about matters of importance to human life.

While analyzing, critical readers;

1. Are aware that texts present ideas, not absolute truths

In order to understand critical reading, we need to examine some of the assumptions about reading. One of the most significant challenges facing anyone who wants to become a critical and analytical reader understands that printed text does not contain inarguable truth. Although a printed text has authority, it does not follow that what is published must be truth. And if it is true, it must be taken at face value, not questioned, challenged, or extended in any way.

Treating texts as if they were sources of ultimate and unquestionable knowledge and truth represents the view of reading as consumption. According to this view, writers produce ideas and knowledge, and we, as readers, consume them, of course, sometimes we have to assume this stance and read for information or the “main point” of a text. But it is critical reading that allows us to create new ideas from what we read and to become independent and creative learners.

Critical reading is simply a collaboration between the reader and the writer. It offers readers the ability to be active participants in the construction of meaning of every text they read and to use that meaning for their own learning and self-fulfillment. Therefore, we as readers need to ask questions and provide different interpretations to text.

Critical readers look for connections between texts

One of the traits of critical readers is their willingness to seek out other texts and people who may be able to help them in making out the meaning of a text. It is important to note that the inability to seek out such connections often turns into a roadblock in attaining the meaning of a text.

The best way to get a connection between texts is by conducting research. Conducting secondary research allows a writer to connect a local problem he or she is investigating and a local solution he or she is proposing with a national and even global context, and to see whether the local situation is typical or atypical.

Research enables good writers to connect the local and the national and the global. It tries to look beyond the surface of the problem beyond simply comparing numbers and other statistics. It seeks to understand the roots of a problem and propose a solution based on a local and well as a global situation and research

Critical readers understand that it is not enough to look at the research question locally or narrowly. After conducting research and understanding their problem locally, or as it applies specifically to them, active researchers contextualize their investigation by seeking out texts and other sources within which would allow them to see the big picture.

In addition to show how related texts can be used to explore various aspects of the writer's own life, research highlights on the need to read texts critically and interpret them creatively. Such reading and research goes beyond simply comparing of facts and numbers and towards relating ideas and concepts with one another.

FROM READING TO WRITING

Critical reading is not a process of passive consumption but one of interaction and engagement between the reader and the text. Therefore, when reading critically and actively, it is important not only to take in the words on the page, but also to interpret and to reflect upon what you read through writing and discussing it with others. The following are the ways to do so.

Critical readers understand the difference between reacting and responding to a text

As observed in our previous lesson, actively responding to texts, posing questions, and analyzing ideas presented in them is the key to successful reading. The goal of an active and critical reader is to engage in a conversation with the text or she is reading. In order to fulfill this goal, it is important to understand the difference between reacting to the text and responding to it.

Reacting to a text is often done on an emotional, rather than on an intellectual level. It is quick and shallow. For example, if we encounter a text that advances arguments with which we strongly disagree, it is natural to dismiss those ideas out of hand as not worthy of our attention. Doing so would be reacting to the text based only on emotions and on our pre-set opinions about its arguments. It is easy to see that reacting in this way does not take the reader any closer to understanding the text.

Responding to a text, on the other hand, requires a careful study of the ideas presented and arguments advanced in it. Critical readers who possess this skill are not willing to simply reject or accept the arguments presented in the text after the first reading right away. Therefore, a critical reader would respond to a text rather than reacting by apply several of the following strategies before forming and expressing an opinion about that text.

- ✚ Read the text several times, taking notes asking questions and underling key places
- ✚ Study why the author of the text advances ideas, arguments, and convictions, so different from the reader's own
- ✚ Study the purpose and the intended audience of the text
- ✚ Study the history of the argument presented in eth text as much as possible. Study the social, political, and intellectual context in which the text was written. Good writers use social conditions to advance their ideas. Compare the context in which the text was written to the one in which it is read. For example, have social conditions changed, thus invalidating the argument or making it stronger?
- ✚ Consider your own previous knowledge of the issue at the center of the text and your experiences with it. How might such knowledge or experience have influenced your reception of the argument?

Taking all these steps will help you to move away from simply reacting to a text and towards constructing informed and critical response to it.

2. Critical readers resist oversimplified responses

Critical readers learn to avoid simple “agree- disagree” responses to complex texts. Such way if thinking and arguing is often called “binary” because it allows only two answers to every statement and to every question.

But critical reading requires a much more nuanced approach when dealing with complex arguments. Therefore, hen you are asked to “critique” a text, it does not mean that you have to “criticize”: what you are being asked to do instead is to carefully evaluate and analyze the text's

ideas, to understand how and why they are constructed and presented, and only then develop a response to that text.

Not every text asks for an outright agreement or disagreement. Sometimes, we as readers are not in a position to either simply support an argument or reject it. What we can do in such cases, though, is to learn more about the texts arguments by carefully considering all of their aspects and to construct a nuanced, sophisticated responses to them. After you have done all that it will be much more informed and nuanced than if you rely on a binary of agree/ disagree approach from the start.

Critical readers do not read alone and in silence

One of the key principles of critical reading is that active readers do not read silently and by themselves. By this I mean that they take notes and write about what they read. They also discuss the texts they are working with, with others and compare their own interpretations of those texts with the interpretations constructed by their colleagues.

Critical reading has other goals, one of which is entering an on- going intellectual exchange. Therefore it demands different reading strategies, approaches, and techniques. One of these new approaches is not reading in silence and alone. Instead, critical readers read with a pen or pencil in hand. They also discuss what they read with others.

LESSON 3

STRATEGIES IN CRITICAL READING AND RESPONSE

Introduction

Critical readers are neither made overnight nor sit back and wait for the meaning of a text to come to them, but work hard in order to create such meaning. Critical readers are able to interact with the texts they read through carefully listening, writing, conversation, and questioning. Therefore, becoming a critical reader will take a lot of practice and patience.

Depending on your current philosophy and experiences with reading becoming a critical reader may require a significant change in your whole understating of the reading process. Below is an outline of the process of critical reading and responses.

1. Previewing

Previewing simply means learning about a text before really reading it. It is one of the initial processes in critical reading and responses. Previewing enables readers to get a sense of what the text is about and how it is organized before reading it closely. Further, previewing enables readers to form meaningful expectations about the reading and hence decide how much time you will dedicate to the reading.

The simplest way to preview a text is through skimming. This enables one to get an overview of the content and organization, and identifying the rhetorical situation. This simple strategy includes

✚ Look for title, section headings, date of publication

✚ Expectations about the author (previous works)

- ✚ Define the important vocabulary words
- ✚ Introductory notes to the text
- ✚ Brief summaries of chapters
- ✚ The goal is to obtain, a general grasp of the text

2. Contextualizing the text

Contextualizing implies placing the text you are reading within particular contexts such as historical, biographical and cultural contexts. When you read a text, you read it through the lens of your own experience. Your understanding of the words on the page and their significance is informed by what you have come to know and value from living in a particular time and place. But the texts you read were all written in the past, sometimes in a radically different time and place. To read critically, you need to contextualize, you recognize the differences between your contemporary values and attitudes and those presented in the text.

Contextualizing starts by you finding out the background information of the author whose text you are reading through asking questions such as: who she/ he is, what else she/ he published, what work she/he does, what cultural background does she/he come from and/ or represent. The gender and cultural background of the author may have a bearing on the author's perspective.

Some of this information can be gained from the foreword, introduction or the back of a book, or at the bottom corner of the first page of an article.

The background information may give you some indication of the author's purpose, the audience (s) she/he typically writes for, who she/he typically collaborates with in research, her/ his ideological orientation or conceptual framework.

It is important to note the date of publication of a text since it implicitly provides the historical context of the text. The historical context in which a text is written can influence the author's thinking and pre-occupations and the date can tell you how up-to-date the material in the text is. This enables a critical reader to make informed judgments while attempting to come up with the meaning of a text.

The context in which an article has been published is relevant to your evaluation as well. In a book that is a collection of articles on a particular topic, the editors' introduction usually provides a very useful summary of each discipline. Some journals are considered particularly important, and particular journals are often associated with particular theoretical approaches.

3. Focusing on the content

As students, you are used to your teachers asking you questions on thematic items of the lesson as you continue learning. More often than not, the questions that your teachers ask are designed to help you understand a lesson better and help you respond to it.

The question-asking techniques also come in handy in critical reading and response. When you need to understand and use new information, it is important for you to write down certain questions as you read the text for the first time. With this strategy, you can write questions any time. By doing this, you will understand the materials better and remember it longer if you write a question for every paragraph or brief section. Each question should focus on a main idea, not on illustrations or details, and each should be expressed in your own words, not just copied from parts of the

paragraph. The whole exercise is meant to enable you understand the content of the text that you are reading.

It is important to note that you are asking questioning to enable you understand the content of the text. The following are some of the questions that you might ask to facilitate your understating of the context:

- ✚ What is the writer's thesis- i.e, the statement or proposition that she/he is arguing to support?
- ✚ How does the author develop the thesis from one point to another?
- ✚ What evidence, examples or explanations are used to support the thesis?
- ✚ Ware the supporting evidence, examples and explanations accurate?
- ✚ Which aspects of the topic has the author chosen to concentrate on? Which aspects have the author not included or discussed?
- ✚ Is the material comprehensive and accurate, or is the subject treated superficially?
- ✚ Are there alternative explanations for the material or data presented? Has the author addressed these alternative explanations?
- ✚ If there are any visual images, how are they linked with the written texts?
- ✚ How does the contents relate to what you know about the topic?
- ✚ Do any items puzzle or intrigue you?

4. Examining your personal Reponses

In examining your personal responses, you reflect on challenges to your beliefs and values in the course of your reading. The reading that you do for this class might challenge your attitudes, your unconsciously held belief or your positions on current issues. As you read a text for the first time.

- ✚ Mark an X in the margin at each point where you feel a personal challenge to your attitudes, beliefs, or status
- ✚ Highlight, or underline parts of the text that you think are very important
- ✚ Make a brief note in the margin about what you feel or about what in the text created the challenge
- ✚ Write a few words in the margin that capture the essence of your reaction
- ✚ Write a few words that will help you to remember the text
- ✚ Now look again at the places you marked, highlighted or underlined in the text as well as the comments you have made where you felt personally challenged. What patterns do you see.

The opinion you form from the above steps form your reaction to the text that you have been reading.

5. Outlining and summarizing

Outlining and summarizing involves identifying the main ideas and restating them in your own words. Outlining and summarizing are important and helpful strategies of understanding the content and structure of a text. Whereas outlining reveals the basic structure of the text, summarizing synthesizes a selection's main argument in brief.

Outlining may be part of the annotating process, or it may be done separately. The key to both outlining and summarizing is being able to distinguish between the main idea and the supporting idea and examples. The main ideas form the backbone, the strand that holds the various parts and pieces of the text together. Outlining the main ideas helps you to discern this structure. When you make an outline, don't use the text's exact words but state them in your own way.

Summarizing begins with outlining, but instead of merely listing the main ideas, a summary recomposes them to form a new text. Whereas outlining depends on a close analysis of each paragraph, summarizing also requires creative syntheses. Putting ideas together again- in your own words and in a condensed form. Shows how reading critically can lead to deeper understanding of any text.

6. Evaluating an argument

In evaluating an argument, you aim at testing the logic of a text as well as its credibility and emotional impact. All writers make assertions that they want you to accept as true. As a critical reader, you should not accept anything on face value but to recognize every assertion as an argument that must be carefully evaluated.

An argument has two essential parts; a claim and support; the claim asserts a conclusion. An idea, an opinion, a judgment, or a point of view. That the writer wants you to accept. The support includes reasons (shared beliefs, assumptions, and values) and evidence (facts, examples, statistics, and authorities) that give readers the basis for accepting the conclusion. When you assess an argument, you are concerned with the process of reasoning as well as its truthfulness (these are not

the same thing). At the most basic level, in order for an argument to be acceptable, the support must be appropriate to the claim and the statements must be consistent with one another.

7. Comparing and contrasting related readings

This process aims at exploring likenesses and differences between texts to understand them better. By making comparisons, a critical reader is able to identify the strengths and weaknesses of one text as compared to the other.

LESSON 4

WAYS FOR CRITICAL READING AND RESPONSE

Introduction

If you want to become a critical reader, you need to get into a habit of writing as you read. You also need to understand that complex texts cannot be read just once. Instead, they require multiple readings, the first of which may be a more general one during which you get acquainted with the ideas presented in the text, its structure and style. During the second and any subsequent readings, however, you will need to write, and write a lot.

The following are some critical reading and writing techniques which active readers employ as they work to create meanings from text they read.

1. Underline interesting and important places in the text

Here you underline

✚ Words, sentences, and passages that stand out, for whatever reasons.

- † Key arguments that you believe the author of the text is making
- † Any evidence, examples, and stories that seem interesting or important. Don't be afraid to "get it wrong". There is no right or wrong here.

The places in the text that you underline may be the same or different from those noticed by your classmates, and this difference of interpretations is the essence of critical reading.

2. Take notes

Take notes on the margins. If you do not want to write on your book or journal, attach post-it notes with your comments to the text. Do not be afraid to write too much. This is the stage of the reading process during which you are actively making meaning. Writing about what you read is the best way to make sense of it, especially, if the text is difficult.

Writing about what you read will help you not only to remember the argument which the author of the text is trying to advance but to create your own interpretations of the texts you are reading which is very important in critical reading. Here are something you can do in your comments:

- † Ask questions
- † Agree or disagree with the author
- † Question the evidence presented in the text
- † Offer counter- evidence, example, stories, and so on that support the author's argument
- † Mention other texts which advance the same or similar arguments
- † Mention personal experiences that enhance your reading of the text

3. Write exploratory responses.

Write extended responses to reading. By writing, reading responses, you are continuing the important work of critical reading which you began when you underlined interesting passages and took notes on the margins. You are extending the meaning of the text by creating your own commentary to it and perhaps even branching off into creating your own argument inspired by your reading

When writing extended responses to the reading of a text, it is important to keep one thing in mind; the purpose. The purpose of these exploratory responses which are often rather informal, is not to produce a complete argument, with an introduction, thesis, body and conclusion. It is not to impress your classmates and your teacher with “big” words and complex sentences. On the contrary, it is to help you understand the text you are working with at a deeper level.

As you investigate and create the meaning of the text you are working with, do not be afraid to take different directions with your reading response. In fact, it is important to resist the urge to make conclusions or think that you have found out everything about your reading. When it comes to exploratory reading responses, lack of closure and presence of more leads at the end of the piece is usually a good thing. Try the following guidelines to write a successful response to a reading.

- ✚ Remember your goal- exploration. The purpose of writing a response is to construct the meaning of a text. It is not to get the job done as quickly as possible and in as few words as possible.
- ✚ As you write, “talk back to the text”. Make comments, ask questions, and elaborate on complex thoughts. This part of the writing becomes much easier if, prior to writing your

response, you had read the assignment with a pen in hand and marked important places in the reading.

- ✚ Bringing in related texts, examples, or experiences. Active reading is about making connections, and your readers will appreciate your work because it will help them understand the text better.
- ✚ While your primary goal is exploration and questioning, make sure that others can understand your response. While it is OK to be informal in your response, make every effort to write in a clear, error-free language
- ✚ Involve your audience in the discussion of the reading by asking questions, expressing opinions and connecting to responses made by others.

4. Keep a double-entry journal/ using the divide page method

In addition to the other ways of critically responding to a text outlined above, you can use a reading journal to track what you are reading and to form critical responses to books articles, chapters etc you have read in their entirety. Many writers like double-entry journals because they allow us to make that leap from summary of a source to interpretations and persuasion.

A reading journal is created by taking down important notes during your reading in a separate piece. To start a double-entry journal:

- ✚ Divide a page into two columns
- ✚ In the left column write down interesting and important words, sentences, quotations, and passage from the text
- ✚ In the right column, write your reaction and responses to them. be as formal or informal as you want.

- † Record words, passages, and ideas from the text that you find useful for your paper, interesting, or in any, way striking or unusual.
- † In the right- hand side column, ask the kinds of questions and provide the kinds of responses that will later enable you to create an original reading of the text you are working with and use that reading to create your own response.
- † Then using your own words, summarize the entire article, text, describe the main points, define key terms, and express your reactions from the important notes that you have taken.
- † Remember you do NOT need to refer back to the text until you absolutely have to! Give your memory a workout force yourself to learn the material as you read and be able to write it down clearly afterwards

5. Using landmark/footnote method

The course of your reading of a text, dedicate an adequate amount of space to the text on a separate piece of paper.

Highlight, mark, or underline a critical art in your reading. In the margin, indicate that you are going to write a footnote. For example, write a 1 or a

In the separate piece of paper, writer a '1' or 'a' (or whatever symbol you chose) and then write your critical response

LITERARY CRITICISM

Overview

For all its shortcomings, literary criticism still provides the poet with the tools for self- evaluation and self- improvement. It introduces work of periods and cultures different in theme and treatment.

Literary criticism comes in various shapes and aims. At best it poses searching questions of the writer, and insists that they understand how the parts, the science and philosophy have different but co existing concepts of truth and meaning. Art in the end cannot be divorced from contemporary life and that consideration leads on to literary theory.

Introduction

Literary critics have many skills (1) but those which the practicing poet needs to acquire are close reading, explication and evaluation. And the first two because most poems fail through lack of care. The originating emotion still clots the lines or, in striving for originality, the work becomes muddled, pretentious or inherent. The incomprehensible can always be taken for the profound of source, and no doubt much get published for that reason, but only the beginner will see publication as the sole purpose of writing. Poems take too much of the writer's time and emotional life blood not to be made as good as possible, and dishonesty will spoil even the best talents. Poems grow through evaluation, that dialogue between the poems say now and what they might with further work. Self appraisal is inescapable.

But the critic's eye is a rare gift, rarer than sainthood, Housman thought, and matters have literary, become more controversial. Criticism is not fashionable, and has been replaced by literary theory in many university departments. (2) the criticism that continues to be written naturally concentrates on established figures. The remainder, the reviewing/ criticism appraising the great torrent that

pours off the small presses, is often partisan, shallow and/ or doggedly optimistic. (3) Even the aims of criticism seem somewhat doubtful. (4) no single critical approach seems invariably successful (5) and insights from differing approaches do not necessarily cohere. Nothing brings finality of judgment, moreover, and one critic's findings can be undone by another's ingenuity. Much more damaging, the premises even of literary theory have been uprooted by radical theory (6)

Purpose of theory

What does literary criticism hope to achieve? There are many schools of thought, (7) but all take as their starting point the analysis of the reader's or listener's response. Poems may be complex, requiring a good deal of explanation or even correction of corrupt scripts, but there has to be an immediate impact of some sort; not very strong, and not blatantly emotional necessarily, but something that allows the critic to ask; how is this obtained? How significant is it? How does it compare with similar works? No impact and there is nothing to analyze. The work has failed, at least where that particular reader is concerned, and no amount of critical cleverness, literary allusions and information will bully him into responding to what he cannot feel.

But who is the reader? Each and everyone, as Stanley fish might claim (8), or Miltons "select audience though few"? Poets may not make money but they still have markets to consider. Whom are they writing for- the editors or leading magazines, friends, society at large, or themselves? and to say something significant about the word around them, to resolve personal quandaries, to gain a literary reputation with those who count? In an ideal world all aim might be served by the one work, but the world is not ideal, and aims needed to be sorted out.

It is the original intention or purpose of writing, that much historical and sociological analysis attempts to understand. In Shakespeare or Chaucer, and much more so in the poetry of ancient Greece or china, there are different conventions to appreciate, and many words cannot be fully translated (9). The difficulties afflict more than the professional translator or literary scholar, as modern poetry very much uses *recherché* imagery and far-flung allusion. A simple word like “faith” would be very differently appreciated in the church –going communities of small- town America and the Nietzsche-reading intelligentsia of London’s Hampstead. The meaning, the literal meaning of the poem, might be the same but not the insights that gave the poem its real subject matter.

With conventions come the expectations of the audience. Sidney wrote for the great country house, Shakespeare for the public stage Middleton for the city. Their work is different in rhetoric, diction and imagery, and had to be social distinctions may be much less marked today, but the intellectual traditions continue. Poets are very choosy about their venues. Writers who live in California will keep a Manhattan address (10) poems that work well on the page will not necessarily rise to a public performance. All this is obvious, what professional prose writers think about before accepting a commission, (11) but is commonly overlooked by the beginning poet.

Is objectivity possible?

Since poets love their creations, and must do to continue writing, how objective can they be? Again, there is much disagreement (12). Some poets, stunned by yet another wrong- headed review, come to believe that they alone, or at least a small circle of like minded poets, have any real critical ability. Only they really know that is good and not so good in their own work. And anyone attending workshops regularly may well agree.

But few academic critics will accept that poets make the sounder judgment (13) not a demarcation dispute, they say, but simple experience and logic. Artists are notoriously partisan, and look at colleague's work to learn and borrow. And consider a Beethoven sonata; we can all distinguish between the beginner and the accomplished pianists even though possessing no piano- playing skills of our own. True, but the analogy is not exact. Poems are written in a language we all read and speak. Even to use language correctly calls on enormously complex skills, so that poetry may be but a small addition, a thin specialization. On that scale the differences between good and bad in poetry may be analogous to deciding between two almost equally good pieces of piano- playing. That exceeds the competence of most of us, and we hand over to the usual competition panel of musicians and conductors.

Certainly we can accept that critics and poets intend different things, namely articles and poems. And that there is nothing to stop the poet becoming an excellent critic. (many have (14) or academic critics from the learning the different art of writing poetry (15). The experience may well be enriching for both. But the question is more insidious. What exactly is it that the critic produces in his article, and how does it shape the reader's response? An earlier generation (much earlier, that encountered by I. A. Richards in his pioneering reading experiments at Cambridge (16) sought to make poems out of their responses. Artists do influence each other, and imitation is no doubt the sincerest form of flattery. But Richard's examinees, and perhaps inevitably, without the time and skills to do a decent job turned in very juvenile work, Richards, could dismiss the approach as entirely wrong headed. Analysis was what was wanted- not adroit phrases but method, the careful reductive method of the sciences. By all means write up the exercise engagingly after words, but

first read with great attention, asking the right questions. So was born the new criticism, and few doubt that this was a large step forward (17).

But that does not invalidate the question. The new critics were now doing what very good poet does or should do- examining and re- examining the work from every conceivable angle: diction, imagery, meaning, shape, etc previous critics had rushed to judgment without putting in the fundamental shade work. But what the new critics produced, the journal article or book, had none of the attraction of the original! Poem, and indeed became increasingly technical employing a jargon that only fellow specialists could enjoy. The general reader was not catered for, any more than poets, most of whom were writing in different styles anyway, with different problems to address. Criticism retreated to academia, and eventually bred a poetry that had a academia for its readership (18)

More than that, criticism became an end in itself (19). The intellectual gymnastic currently performed by the great names of American criticism are not grounded in the poem being analyzed, but in the tenets of radical theory. The poem may serve as the original impetus, as something about which to parade their skills, (20) but the criticism has detached itself and become somewhat like a modernists poem. It draws inspiration from literary theories, and these can be nebulous or plainly wrong. Speculative theory poets working in other traditions, but does underline and earlier question: what is the status, the ontological status, of the critical article?

School of criticism

Suppose we bear that question in mind in surveying the various schools of criticism. There are many but could perhaps be grouped as:

Traditional

Though perhaps Edwardian in style, this approach- essentially one of trying to broaden understanding and appreciation- is still used in general surveys of English literature. There is usually some information on the writer and his times, and a little illustration, but no close analysis of the individual work or its aims.

New criticism

The poem (the approach works best for poetry, and especially the lyric) is detached from its biographical or historical content, and analyzed thoroughly; diction, imagery, meaning, particularly complexities of meaning. Some explanation of unfamiliar words and/ or uses may be allowed, but the poem is otherwise expected to stand on its own feet, as though it were a contemporary production.

Rhetorical

Rhetoric is the art of persuasion and the rhetorical approach attempts to understand how the content of the poem, which is more than intellectual meaning, is put across. How arguments are presented, attitudes struck, evidence marshaled, various appeals made to the reader- all are relevant.

Stylistic

Style is the manner in which something is presented, and this approach concentrates on the peculiarities of direction and imagery employed, sometimes relating them to literary and social theory.

Metaphorical

Metaphor enters into consideration in most approaches, but here the emphasis is deeper and more exclusive, attention focusing on the ways that metaphors actually work, metaphors are not regarded as supporting or decorative devices, but actually constituting the meaning.

Structuralists

Here the writing is related to underlying patterns of symmetry which are held to be common to all societies. Evidence is drawn from sociology and anthropology, and the approach attempts to place the work in larger context rather than assess its quality.

Post structuralist

In contrast to the new critic approach, which stresses, interdependence and organic unity, the post structuralist will point to the dissonances and the non sequiturs, and suggests how the poem works by evading or confronting traditional expectations.

Myth theory

The approach derives from Northrop Frye and attempts to place poems into categories or subcategories into which all literature is divided by archetypal themes. E.g. the myth of the hero, is subjugation of enemies, his fall. The approach somewhat anticipated structuralism draws on

various psychologies, and is less concerned with isolating what is special than showing what it has in common with works in a similar category.

Freudian

Not only is the diction examined for sexual imagery, but the whole work is seen through Freudian concepts: struggles of the superego, the Oedipus complex, with the repressed contents of consciousness, etc. the aim is illuminating of psychic conflicts, not aesthetic ranking.

Jungian

Jungians search for recurring poetic images, symbols and situations in poems, but their aims is not to categorize poems as Northrop Frye does but to relate them to larger patterns in society, whether native peoples or high civilizations.

Historical

Poems are placed in their historical context- to explain not only their allusions and particular use of words, but the conventions and expectations of the times the approach may be evaluative (i.e. the critic may suggest ways of responding to the poem once the perspective is corrected) or may simply use it as historical data.

Biographical

As with the historical approach, a poem may be used to illuminate the writer's psychology, or as biographic data. No less than the correspondence, remembered conversations, choice of reading matter, the poem is analyzed for relevance to its author.

Sociological

Here the focus on society as a whole, and critics assess the social factors at work in a poem, which may be everything from the attitudes a writer inherits from his social background to the markets which supported his literary efforts.

Political

It may be the political movements the poet supported which interest the critic, but more commonly the poem is assessed on political lines; how fairly or effectively it promotes political action or attitudes.

Marxists

The poem may be assessed on its political correctness on its support for workers against capitalists exploitation but most Marxists praise work that analysis or describes the injustices which Marxist societies aim to overcome

Moralists

Many poets have strong ethical or religious convictions, but the moralists critic usually has a broader interest. Literature has a humanizing or civilizing mission, and the critic values work which furthers that end; promotes tolerance, social justice, sensitivity to individual wishes and talents etc.

Cognitive scientific

In contrast to others, which generally possess a humanities orientation, that of cognitive science attempts to relate poems to patterns of brain functioning. The approach is in its infancy, but holds some promise in the fractal self-similarity exhibited by works of art.

Testing the approaches

Which approach is best? That which proves the most illuminating is the usual answer. The various approaches are not entirely distinct and one can aim for a wise eclecticism (21), incorporating several approaches in the one article. Certainly this adds length and multiple perspectives to the critical article, but are the individual approaches sound in themselves? They may provide more matter to ponder, but that is surely no proof of value.

Suppose that the critical approach employed was not only shaky but fatuously offensive. An extreme example might be a Nazi appraisal of German writers which graded them crudely on their genetic makeup, from Blonde Aryans (good) to eastern Jew (atrocious). Would we add this approach to the others? If we say emphatically not, then we must accept that critical approaches need support that we can independently assess. And this innocuous request raises the ominous problems of truth and meaning.

These are real and important. If literature had no truth to convey, there would be nothing to distinguish it from reaction or entertainment. Governments might support the arts to keep a restless society off the streets, but truth would remain the province of science, where bureaucrats went for

information to back policy decisions. But in fact art, logic and science all have truth, different and no doubt wary of each other, but not fundamentally at loggerheads. Art aims at fullness and fidelity to human experience and therefore includes the wider social spectrum.

No doubt to return to Germany, we could argue that our example would not happen in practice.

The Nazi article would not in any way clarify our responses to German writers. But suppose it did?

A critic appealing to nationalists sentiments might very well have been plausible to his contemporary audience. We ourselves might even find some merit in the judgments, unless we were very insensitive to Jewish problems in thirties Germany, and lumped all German writers together, we would not be able to help noticing differences in setting and outlook which had a material bearing on the writing. It might be a fearfulness of hopelessness in the outlook or actions of the main protagonists, and we should have to ask ourselves whether the work presented a true view of humanity, or was simply an historical aberration. Wider issues always obtrude, and we have either an ethos to defend, or to find a theory independent of time and context.

The latter was one hope of radical theory, which undercut the varied and apparently successful criticism of the nineteen fifties and sixties by adopting the approaches of philosophy and science. Not only cutbacks in university tenure, or the end of the publishing boom, (22) but an unexamined belief in its right to exist, led to the downfall of traditional literary study. Of course it is possible to argue for a literal, pluralists, democratic approach, but the argument least through to philosophical, political and sociological matters, and here the radical critics seize the armory. The new critics had dismissed the larger context of literary criticism, and the moralists carried little weight. The radical demanded that poetry represent its age, and that age they viewed through the spectacles of left- wing and continental philosophic concerns.

Their arguments, though perhaps not the tactics, were certainly needed approaches do matter, and they must justify themselves before a wider tribunal if art is to be more than make-believe. Hence the theory section of this guide. A descriptive critic may simply not the characteristics of the new poetry capturing academic interest, (23) even its declining readership, but the practicing poet needs to examine the theories underlying and supporting new work. If simply faddish and incoherent then the poems are unlikely to possess any lasting value.

Is criticism a sham?

But does criticism really work? Do we analyze carefully and consult our books on theory before responding to a word? Not usually impressions come first. But we then have to think why and how we are responding in a certain way. Is the poem strained, hackneyed, overworked, etc? and if so, by what criteria? In setting out thoughts on paper, and then attempting to substantiate them, we are honing essential skills

Perhaps a good deal of academic criticism is suspect. The goal is already known: certain authors are to be esteemed, and criticism has simply to find additional support. Often the canon intervenes crudely. Literature is divided into essential writers {which all students must, and other works be compared to}, the acceptable {enjoyable but not to be taken too seriously} and the bad {which no one will confess to liking}. The canon is consulted and the reason found for praising or condemning the writer concerned. Literally guides are replete with examples, and argument is often puerile- the dismissive sneer, the appeal to the knowledgeable, right-thinking majority, the comparison of a poor poem by the despised author with a good one by the favoured. But the inanities only underline the need for sharper and independent reading skills Background and temperament ensure that there

will be some writers we shall never like, but we do not have to concoct false reasons for our own tastes.

Practical critiquing

Now a change of tone. Suppose we look at criticism in practice, at what a young poet might be told, who's pleased with his poem, and doesn't need analysis to know it's good. Tactfully and more modestly than in these notes, we might have to say;

But have you checked- got a colleague to read it through, asked a tutor presented the piece at a poetry workshop? Readers are perverse creatures, and will cavil in strange ways. Anticipate. Criticize the piece yourself, in your own time, from all angles, before the wounding remarks bring you up short. Remember that evaluation is not a handing down of judgments, but a slow acquisition of essential writing skills.

Appraisal needs honesty and independent judgment, plus a whole battery of techniques that literary critics have developed over the centuries. The better libraries will have long shelves devoted to literary criticism, which you must read and absorb. Indeed you must put pen to paper yourself, and write your own notes and essay. As an everything literary, perception develops with your ability to express and reflect on that perception.

What are the techniques of poetry analysis, and which are worth acquiring? Even on a simple poem you will find a wide range of comments, many of them perplexing if not downright daft. Which critics can you trust for sensible and enlightening comments?

You must make your own judgments. That is the nature of literary criticism. Moreover, until you can appraise the various critical attitudes, weighing up the strengths and shortcomings of each

approach, you are evaluating but just borrowing undigested material, for the students essay. That may win you good grades, but it won't help with unfamiliar work, or develop the skills needed to rescue your own productions

Writers and critics develop at their own pace, and the more precocious are not always the more lasting. Talented authors commonly write from something buried deep within, from something that is ungraspable but troubling, and which seems not to fit any of the established criteria progress in such class is bound to be slow, and perhaps should be if the issues are being properly addressed. But you're not working against a stopwatch, you have a lifetime to appreciate the great writes and to understand what you are attempting yourself.

Suggestions

1. Start with the literary criticism of poems you know and love. You will be more engaged by the arguments, and start to understand how criticism can open unsuspected levels of meaning and significance.
2. Read literary criticism of contemporary work and, if at all possible, of poems similar to your own, which will at least help you anticipate the reception likely from editors and workshop presentations.
3. Research has moved from literary criticism to literary theory, which is not written for ready comprehension nonetheless, you will need to know where critics are coming from, and therefore the theoretical bases of their remarks.

4. Don't despise the elementary grounding provided by schoolbooks. University texts have much to do with academic reputations and tenure, but those for younger students aim more to help and encourage.
5. Be severe but not over- severe with your creations. You enjoyed writing them, and that pleasure must still be on the page to enthuse, challenge and enchant your readers. The merely correct has little to comment it.
6. Use a checklist. For example:

Title: appropriate to subject, tone and genre? Does it generate interests, and hint at what your poem's about?

Subject- what's the basic situation? Who is taking, and under what circumstances? Try writing a paraphrase to identify any gaps or confusions.

Shape- what are you appealing to intellect or emotions of the reader? What structure (s) have you used. Progressions, comparisons, analogies, bald assertions, etc? are these aspects satisfyingly integrated? Does structure support content?

Tone- what's your attitude to the subject? Is it appropriate to content and audience: assured, flexible, sensitive, etc?

Word choice- appropriate and uncontrived, economical, varied and energizing? Do you understand each word properly, its common uses and associations? See if listing the verbs truly pushes the poem along. Are words repeated? Do they set mood, emotional rapport, distance?

Personification- striking but persuasive, adds to unity and power?

Metaphor and simile- fresh and convincing, combining on many levels?

Rhythm and metre- natural, inevitable, integrate poem's structure?

Rhyme (if employed) – fresh pleasurable unassuming but supportive?

Overall impression- original, honest, coherent, expressive, significant?

Conclusions

Why practice criticism at all? Because it's interesting, and opens the door to a wider appreciation of poetry, particularly that in other languages.

It's also unavoidable. Good writing needs continual appraisal and improvement, and both are better done by the author, before the work is set in print. Most academics write article rather than poems, but these seems no reason why their skills should not deployed in creating things which by their own submission are among the most demanding and worthwhile of human creations. Not should poets despise professional literary criticism. In short, the approaches of this section should give poets some of the tools needed to assess their work, and to learn from the successful creations of others.

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